

ration, searching and browsing, user ratings and trust. Privacy and other issues such as false identities and addiction will be examined, and finally some statistics on the various sites will be presented.

3.1 Communication and Collaboration Features

As well as the basic social networking features of user searching and profile browsing, many sites like orkut and Tribes offer a range of community building primitives. These include features allowing the building of communities, based on memberships with read and/or write privileges, and special communication features like message boards and event lists. Current technological developments point to future social networking collaboration and communication techniques by means of mobile phones or network connected portable devices.

User to All

Weblogs or “blogs” have become a popular tool for users to make their opinions known online, and with at least 5 million weblogs in existence (Blogger has 1.5 million, LiveJournal 700,000 and Xanga 2.5 million), social networking sites such as Ecademy and Friendzy have begun to incorporate blogging or “story” features. Blogs are often exported to RSS or Atom XML formats for use by news aggregator software such as Radio User Land. User profiles allow a user to communicate their personal and professional details to all other users on a social networking site, for example, their age, their employer’s industry type or even their favorite TV show. Another method of user to all communication is by means of a user’s Friend of a Friend file [8], which is a standardized method of expressing the information usually found in a user profile, but can incorporate new fields as needed. Ecademy provides user profile information in FOAF format.

User to User

Most user to user communication on social networking sites is carried out by means of private messaging (PM) functions (e.g. using the “Personal Messages” module on Friendster), similar to sending